THE NIGHT WINDOW

An Original Short Screenplay

Story Factory host-agent demonstration

Revised demonstration draft -- 20 October 2026

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FADE IN:

INT. NIGHT REPAIR KIOSK -- NIGHT

A row of screwdrivers stands in a toothbrush cup. MAE, 43, a woman in an immaculate, repeatedly mended work coat, straightens the shortest one.

The clock reads 11:42. Mae counts cash: one hundred and eighty. She puts it in an envelope marked LEASE RENEWAL. Her terminal displays a renewal payment due at midnight. Below it: PAY TO RENEW.

She presses CONFIRM. A squeak from the window. INEZ, 31, a woman in a reflective delivery vest, pushes a handheld scanner through the opening.

INEZ
It gave up at quarter past.

MAE
Battery or screen?

INEZ
If I knew, this would be a social visit.

Mae places it on a clean square of felt. Inez keeps her fingers on its strap.

MAE
Diagnostic is twelve.

INEZ
You put the battery in.

MAE
That doesn't make everything it does my idea.

Inez feeds a receipt through the slot. The scanner sale is dated three weeks ago. BATTERY: NEW. 180. Mae stops straightening things.

INT. NIGHT REPAIR KIOSK -- CONTINUOUS

Inez turns her phone toward Mae. A route roster: INEZ / SAL / DEV. Below: MORNING CONTRACT -- CONFIRM WITH ACTIVE SCANNER BEFORE 00:00.

INEZ
I bought this so three of us could take the morning route. The warehouse won't confirm on a phone.

MAE
Twenty years of phones. Still not a phone.

INEZ
You have eighteen minutes to make that less interesting.

Mae points at the strap. Inez releases it. Mae loosens four screws, placing each in its own numbered recess. Inez reaches for a stool outside the window. Its chain catches.

MAE
Lift, then turn.

Inez does. The stool settles. Mae tests the scanner at a bench supply. It lights, then dies as she removes the cable.

MAE
Battery.

INEZ
We could have saved twelve.

Mae opens the case. Under the battery's neat white stock label, a corner is brown. She presses it flat with her thumb.

INT. NIGHT REPAIR KIOSK -- NIGHT

11:47. Mae applies a magnifier to the battery seam. Inez watches her thumb instead.

INEZ
What's underneath?

MAE
Adhesive.

INEZ
You've looked at it three times.

Mae lifts the label. Embossed into the metal: R17. She sets the battery down behind the magnifier.

INEZ
Is R a good letter?

MAE
Refurbished batch.

INEZ
My receipt has a different word.

Mae opens a ledger beneath the bench. Inez hears its pages. Mae finds R17, then closes it with one finger between the leaves.

MAE
Sometimes the supplier--

She doesn't finish. Inez pulls the scanner strap back toward herself. The open case catches against the window frame. Both women catch it before it falls. For a moment they hold the same fragile object.

MAE
Keep it level.

INEZ
I'm doing half.

Mae lowers her end. Inez lowers hers. Mae tears a blank strip from the receipt roll. She lays it over R17 and rubs a pencil sideways. The letters emerge. She hands the rubbing to Inez.

INEZ
Can you put a new one in?

MAE
Not until morning.

INEZ
Morning is what I'm trying to buy.

Mae reaches for a drawer of batteries. Different sizes. She tries none of them.

MAE
These won't fit.

INEZ
I appreciate the tour.

Mae shuts the drawer. Inez smooths the serial rubbing beside her sale receipt. Two records that cannot both be right.

INT. NIGHT REPAIR KIOSK -- NIGHT

11:50. Inez unfolds the bottom half of her route contract. A printed box: PARTS DISPUTE -- SIGNED SELLER CORRECTION REQUIRED. REVIEW IS NOT A PAYMENT COMMITMENT.

INEZ
They can review the lost booking if the seller corrects a bad part number.

MAE
Review.

INEZ
I can read the disappointing part.

She scrolls on her phone to another form. ACCIDENTAL DAMAGE.

INEZ
Or I dropped it.

MAE
Did you?

INEZ
I'm offering to become clumsy. Our equipment cover pays for clumsy.

MAE
Then next month your cover costs more.

INEZ
Next month exists if we get tomorrow.

Mae pulls the ledger out fully. Her own neat columns: R17 / REFURB / SOLD AS NEW. She turns it to face Inez.

INEZ
That's your handwriting.

MAE
I had six left. I was going to replace them when the shipment came.

INEZ
You charged me before it came.

Mae looks at the lease envelope beside her terminal. Inez follows the look.

MAE
I can give you a loan scanner. Tomorrow. No charge.

INEZ
Will it go back to tonight?

Inez closes the accidental-damage form without submitting it. Mae takes a correction pad, then places it out of reach of the window.

MAE
Let me work out what I can do.

INEZ
Do it where I can see.

Inez leaves the stool. The chain drags across concrete. Mae remains behind the glass with the open ledger.

EXT. KIOSK PAVEMENT -- NIGHT

11:53. Inez leans against a shuttered shop next to the kiosk. She edits the roster: replaces the three names with CONTRACT UNCONFIRMED. She types a message, deletes it, types: Don't set alarms yet. She sends that.

Mae comes through the kiosk's side door carrying a carbon pad. The door closer pulls at her elbow. She braces it with her shoe.

MAE
I thought you were leaving.

INEZ
I moved four feet.

Mae lets the door shut. The latch catches. She checks her pocket for the key. Finds it. Inez permits herself a very small smile.

MAE
I can return the hundred and eighty.

INEZ
And the correction.

MAE
That goes to the platform. They send those to the parts supplier. The supplier can freeze my account.

INEZ
Your ledger already knows.

MAE
My ledger doesn't have a suspend button.

Inez's phone vibrates: CONFIRMATION WINDOW CLOSES IN 7 MINUTES. She turns it face down.

INEZ
Sal has the van. Dev bought the cool boxes. I said the scanner was the sensible expense.

MAE
It was.

INEZ
It was new.

Mae draws a line on the carbon pad. Writes REFUND. Pauses before writing anything beneath it.

MAE
Come inside. The pencil goes through this on the glass.

INEZ
That was almost a reason.

Mae unlocks the side door. This time she holds it for Inez.

INT. NIGHT REPAIR KIOSK -- NIGHT

11:56. Inez is on Mae's side of the window. There is barely room for them. She moves the chained stool so Mae can reach the drawer.

Mae lays out the refund, the correction and the lease envelope. On the refund: FULL AND FINAL SETTLEMENT. Inez reads it, takes the pencil and crosses those words out.

MAE
That's the form.

INEZ
Then you've repaired a form.

Inez writes PURCHASE PRICE ONLY. She pushes the correction forward. Mae draws it back.

MAE
Cash tonight. No one waits for re-view.

INEZ
I lose the route either way. This says I can't ask for the booking money.

MAE
It says you got your money back.

INEZ
Then leave just that.

Mae takes the sheet, seems about to tear it off. Instead she initials the crossed-out words. The carbon copy shows the change too.

INEZ
I don't need your whole book. Just the line with my part.

Mae covers the other customers' rows with scrap paper. Inez photographs R17 beside her original receipt.

Mae opens the lease envelope. Counts the money onto the felt. There is nothing left inside. She folds the empty flap, opens it again, and checks.

INEZ
Is that all of it?

MAE
One hundred and eighty. You saw me count.

Mae looks at the terminal. PAYMENT SCHEDULED 00:00. A small button: CANCEL RENEWAL PAYMENT. She touches it. A confirmation box fills the screen.

INT. NIGHT REPAIR KIOSK -- NIGHT

11:59. Mae presses YES. The terminal displays: PAYMENT CANCELED. CALL OFFICE AT NINE. She removes the little RENEWED TOMORROW card from the window.

She signs the correction. I supplied R17 as new. It was refurbished. No explanation after it. She dates and signs both copies.

MAE
Use the original. Carbon sometimes won't scan.

Inez holds up the correction. The glass reflects her phone flash straight back. She turns the paper, shielding it with her vest. Takes a readable photo.

Her phone: ROUTE CONFIRMATION CLOSED. She touches the grey button once. It stays grey. Then she opens PARTS DISPUTE.

MAE
Did it go?

INEZ
The route? Yes.

Mae places the scanner's back on its case. One screw. Then she realizes the battery is still on the bench and removes the screw again. Inez looks away, gives her that privacy.

Inez uploads the correction. A spinning circle. She counts the cash while it turns. Not quickly.

INEZ
One hundred and eighty.

She signs PURCHASE PRICE ONLY and hands Mae the copy. Mae returns the failed battery in a clear bag, with R17 facing out.

INT. NIGHT REPAIR KIOSK -- LATER

12:02. Inez's phone: DISPUTE RECEIVED. NO PAYMENT DECISION. She photographs that too. Updates the roster: Route lost. Refund received. I'll call at eight.

Mae writes R17 / RETURNED / REFUND 180 in her ledger. Beneath it: RENEWAL -- CALL. She puts the empty envelope under the terminal.

INEZ
How much for the short cable?

MAE
Eight.

INEZ
New?

Mae tests the cable. Turns the package over so Inez can read it.

MAE
Opened. Tested. Eight.

Inez puts eight on the felt. Mae rings it through. Inez folds the new receipt around the cable and takes her scanner.

At the side door, Inez lifts the stool chain clear so the door can close. Mae returns to the bench. She pulls another white label off an old battery, exposing the stamped R.

Outside, Inez checks her phone, then puts it away. Inside, Mae writes REFURBISHED on the next stock label. The pencil scratches in the small lit space.

FADE TO BLACK.

THE END